

Pace of Change

The AI argument is getting louder and louder. Why? Because the technology is advancing at blazing speeds.

ChatGPT three years ago vs today

	3 YEARS AGO	TODAY
Answering	It started typing the instant you hit enter, with whatever came out first.	It can work on a hard problem quietly before it says a word, sometimes for minutes.
Images	Ask for a picture of your new dog Spot and he might come back with a bonus leg and the ears of a rabbit.	Photoreal images with signs you can actually read, and full video with sound and dialogue.
Memory	The free chatbots most people used could only hold a few pages at once. Push a long chat far enough and the beginning fell out of its head.	The latest models hold a million tokens, which is a whole novel series in view at the same time.
Doing	It told you the steps to do a thing, and wished you luck.	It does the thing. It books, builds, files, and fixes while you watch.

The AI companies are in a race to dominate the industry, so they release new models every couple of months. Each new ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini release is a new, stronger LLM replacing the one before it. Whatever AI can't do today, there's a solid chance it can do it next year.

WHY SO FAST?

Three concepts are driving the acceleration, and you already understand the first one.

ACCELERANT 1 Training	ACCELERANT 2 Compute	ACCELERANT 3 AI building AI
WHAT'S HAPPENING AI is trained on more—and often better—data. That gives it more examples and patterns to learn from, but quality matters as much as quantity. Same recipe you learned in Training.	WHAT'S HAPPENING AI requires lots of chips sitting in data centers, cranking through the math. AI companies are spending billions to increase their compute.	WHAT'S HAPPENING By 2026 the strongest models write code well enough that AI companies use them to help write and optimize parts of the software for the next model. On some well-defined coding and research tasks, they can move much faster than people.

Slow down and read that third one again. AI helps build better AI.



4 FUTURE IDEAS

What does the future of AI look like? There are four key ideas driving the AI companies forward. One is being tested now, and no one knows if the other three are even possible.

HAPPENING NOW Automated AI Research AI REPLACES HUMAN RESEARCHERS Human researchers do the work of making each new model smarter. The goal is simple. Replace the human researchers with AI. Humans only review the work. Early versions are already in use. WHAT IT MEANS Should it work, AI progress stops being limited by how many human researchers exist. The pace you saw above gets another boost, from AI researchers that never sleep.	CONTESTED Recursive Self-Improvement SELF-IMPROVING AI An AI that improves itself while the world is using it. Today's models are frozen after training. This one would never stop learning, rewriting its own design and code. Nobody has built one. WHAT IT MEANS Should it be built, AI improvement stops arriving in releases. No new model to wait for every few months: the AI you used yesterday is already smarter today.
HYPOTHETICAL Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) AI AS SMART AS PEOPLE A hypothetical AI that can handle any intellectual task a human can. Some researchers say it's a few years away, some say decades, some say the term is too fuzzy to mean anything. WHAT IT MEANS Should it arrive, any work a person can do on a computer, AI could do too, in every subject and every language at once. That would reach nearly every job and classroom on Earth.	MORE HYPOTHETICAL Artificial Superintelligence (ASI) AI SMARTER THAN EVERYONE AI smarter than any human at everything. This idea is what the loudest hopes and fears are really about. WHAT IT MEANS Should it arrive, the biggest decisions in medicine, money, and defense would involve something smarter than the people in charge of them.

SO WHERE DOES IT STOP?

Nobody knows, and the Loudest Voices lesson showed you how openly the people building it admit that.

AI keeps getting faster and more powerful.

Nobody is sure where it stops.